

FINLAND



A LAND OF LAKES AND FORESTS, Finland is bordered by Russia to the east, the Baltic Sea to the south, and Sweden and Norway to the west and north. Finland shares government of Lapland, in the Arctic Circle, with Sweden and Norway. Finland was ruled by Russia until 1917, and, as a result, Finns have more in common culturally with the east than with their Scandinavian neighbours. A wealthy, liberal nation, Finland was the first European country to give women the vote.

FINLAND FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Helsinki
AREA	338,130 sq km (130,552 sq miles)
POPULATION	5,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Finnish, Swedish
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Euro
LIFE EXPECTANCY	77 years
PEOPLE PER DOCTOR	333
GOVERNMENT	Multi-party democracy
ADULT LITERACY	99%

Physical features

From the air, Finland is a patchwork of lakes, peat bogs, and trees. Forests dominate the land, and water covers about ten per cent of the country. There are some 98,000 islands within the lakes, and 30,000 off the coast. The Arctic north, including part of Lapland, is a bleak area of rocky tundra.

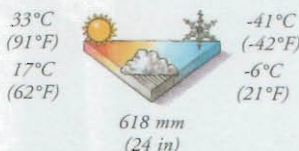


Forests

Pine, spruce, and birch trees cover 80 per cent of Finland, making it the ninth most forested country in the world. The forest is most dense just south of the Arctic Circle and is often covered in snow.

Lakes and islands

Finland has more than 60,000 lakes, mainly in the southeast, carved out by glaciers in the last Ice Age. Many islands are scattered in the lakes and off the warm southwest coast, including 6,000 of the Åland Islands.



Climate

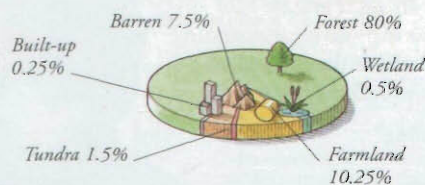
Finland has short, bright summers and long, cold winters when lakes often freeze up to 1 m (3 ft 3 in) deep. The Arctic north sees midnight sun in its 73-day summer.

People

Almost half of the population lives around Helsinki. Families are close-knit, and most homes have a sauna, or hot, steamy relaxation room. Women enjoy equal rights and about 50 per cent pursue a career.

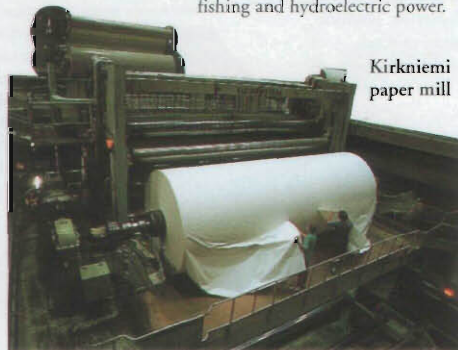


Cooling off after the sauna



Land use

Dense forests and a maze of lakes, rivers, and peat bogs mean only 11 per cent of Finland's land can be used for crops or grazing animals. Despite this, farmers produce all of the country's dairy foods. The forests support a valuable timber industry, and the waters are used for fishing and hydroelectric power.



Kirkniemi paper mill

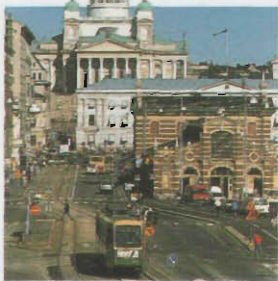
Farming and industry

Finland produces all of its own food. Most crops are grown in the southwest and on the sunny Åland Islands. The country is a world leader in the production of plywood, wood pulp, and paper, and these alone make up 30 per cent of the total exports. Furniture and high-tech manufacturing compete in world markets and, with the service sector, employ the majority of the work-force.



Helsinki

Standing on a peninsula and several islands in the Gulf of Finland, the vibrant capital of Helsinki has about 770,000 inhabitants. Tree-lined avenues and a colourful market back onto a busy harbour. Only half of the city's area has been developed, leaving parkland for the residents to enjoy.



The bustling Helsinki harbour

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